

merely informed about the coming nuptials. The other extreme is the self-arranged marriage where the young people who fall in love unconsciously make sure that the potential mate fulfils all the criteria the family expects of the marriage partner. An intriguing form of arranged marriage, masquerading as a marriage out of love, is seen in Indian movies where the young lovers finally get married after defying vehement opposition of their families. In the feeling of well-being produced by the movie's happy end, we often fail to notice that the love marriage of the hero and the heroine has become an arranged one when one or the other set of parents withdraws its opposition to the love match and both sets of parents come together at the end of the movie to bless the couple.

The Indian preference for arranged marriage is partly based on the young person's acceptance of the cultural definition of marriage as a family rather than individual affair, where harmony and shared values that come from a common background are more important than individual fascination. More significant, though, is the operation of a less conscious cultural norm which perceives the parent-son and fraternal bonds as the foundation of the family rather than the husband-wife tie exalted in modern Western societies. In the

traditional Indian view, which still exerts a powerful influence on how most Indians view marriage, the couple is not the primary constituent of the family.

The tension between these two different visions of the foundation of family life is the basis of the popularity of the *saas-bahu*—the cruel mother-in-law and the suffering daughter-in-law (including the eventual triumph of the younger woman over her older antagonist)—stories which are the staple of many women's songs, folktales and television soaps. Whereas the *bahu* stands for the primacy of the couple, the *saas* is a symbol for the continuing preeminence of filial and fraternal bonds. Abundantly aware of the power of sexual love to overturn time-honoured norms, the larger family is rightly concerned that the young wife may become the reason for her husband neglecting his duties as a son, as a brother, a nephew, an uncle; of transferring his loyalty and affection to the new wife rather than remaining truly a son of the house.

These are not either/or choices; however, custom, tradition and interests of the family demand that in the realignment of roles and relationships initiated by the son's marriage, the couple does not take centre stage, at least not in the early years of marriage. The much-maligned *saas* is



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